Vithaldas Damodar Thackersey, whom we encountered earlier, made an unwarranted remark in the Indian Industrial Conference held in the Congress pavilion on 26 December while moving a resolution to encourage mining, weaving and sugar industries and the formation of joint-stock companies for this purpose. He urged, 'people should not allow themselves to be drawn away by mere enthusiasm and sentiment but should satisfy themselves that the companies were founded on a solid basis', making a pointed reference to 'the appeal issued by the SSNCo in which no facts and figures were given but an appeal to patriotism was made …' Firstly, this flew in the face of the Indian Industrial Conference's annual report, which noted not only the 'steady progress' made by SSNCo but also registered 'the most pressing need' for more capital: 'On the result of the vigorous efforts that are being put forth by a number of devoted workers to get the full amount of the registered capital subscribed by the public will depend the ultimate fate of this remarkable enterprise.'[120] Sir Vithaldas' gratuitous comment did not go down well with the audience. G. Subramania Iyer, who was on the podium, deplored his negative reference to SSNCo and hoped that patriots would ignore his comment. In a bid to ease the tension, the chair, Mudholkar, soft-pedalled the issue by making a general appeal for philanthropy.[121] The matter did not end there. Sir Vithaldas, repaired to Tuticorin immediately after the conference, to make a personal assessment of the company's financial position.[122] Presumably, either G. Subramania Iyer or S.D. Krishna Aiyangar had prevailed upon him to make amends for his gratuitous observation. Nothing came of this visit though. But clearly, partisans of SSNCo were touchy and would not brook uncharitable remarks.

Capital Raised

What did all this strenuous canvassing add up to?

In all, after some hiatus in the collection between March and August 1908, SSNCo had raised Rs 52,000 through subscription of shares and debentures though only Rs 38,000 had been realized. Almost half of this came from the Raja of Venkatagiri (Rs 15,000) and the Raja of Bobbili (Rs